

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

An Enduring Advent ~ Peace
7 December 2025
Advent 2



Emerging Star 1 (revisited) © 2015 Virginia Wieringa, virginiawieringa.com Used by permission

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on ST. COLUMBIA and TAULÈ

Nun komm der Heiden Heiland (Dietrich Buxtehude) and Improvisation

"Gloria" from *The Mass* (Patrick Cassidy) and Improvisation

Walking In The Air (Howard Blake)

Peace (Karen Beaumont) and Improvisation

Toccata in F Major (Johann Pachelbel) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

The Lighting of the Advent Candles

Advent Words of Gathering

Rev. Michael Lehman & Gavin Gregorio

The Peace of God-With-Us does not come as law and order, or enforcement and control.
Peace cannot be imposed from on high. Peace cannot be commanded.

The Peace of God-With-Us is chaotic, wild, unruly, unpredictable.
The Peace of God-With-Us is collective, liberating us from deadly complicity.

Peace is gestating in sacred darkness; it comes unexpectedly.
Peace invites our expectation and our participation.

Prepare the way for peace with justice.

*May Peace be birthed among, within, and through us, this Advent.
O Come, O Come, Emmanuel...*

-adapted from enfleshed

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Advent Hymn of Gathering

Advent Hymn of Gathering *Toda la Tierra - All the Earth is Waiting

TAULÈ

Toda la tierra espera al Salvador
Y el surco abierto, la obra del Creador;
El mundo que lucha por la libertad
Reclama justicia y busca la verdad.

All earth is waiting to see the Promised One,
and open furrows await the seed of God.
All the world, bound and struggling, seeks true liberty;
it cries out for justice and searches for the truth.

Thus says the prophet to all the earth's people:
'A virgin mother will bear Emmanuel,'
one whose name is 'God with us' our savior shall be;
with them hope will blossom once more within our hearts.

***Advent Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, Creator of Advent peace and hope,
Light of harmony and abundance,
Life that proclaims life,
accompany us in our work today and every day.

*Tender bud of new dreams,
Seed of eternity,
Safe of infinite wisdom,
nourish our thoughts, affirm our decisions.*

Sun of justice and of grace,
Warm flame of forgiveness,
Clear gaze of mercy,
wrap us in the security of your presence.

*Announcement of good news,
Evangelist of pardon,
Word that creates and restores,
speak to our hearts, affirm our faith.*

God with us,
Sacred Parent from the beginning to the end,
Promise, reality, alpha and omega,
embrace us with your blessing
and on this day, give us your peace.

-Gerardo Oberman, Argentina

With hearts filled with gratitude for your love and care,
together we say,
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Go Tell It On The Mountain"
The Commonwealth, Brandon Harris, *Director*

TRADITIONAL

***The Lord's Prayer**

Shalonda Martin

*Emmanuel, God-with-us,
Your name is beyond all naming.
May the gentleness of your loving reign take root upon earth;
May your heart's own longings unfold within us
and within all who wait for you in hope.*

*Sustain us, moment by moment,
with the strength to endure in our waiting.
Forgive us when we falter or wound,
and grant us grace to forgive
all those whose wounding has hindered our lives.*

*Spare us trials heavier than we can bear;
yet, in your tender mercy,
journey beside us through the sacred shadows of this season.*

*For in you rests the fullness of creation,
its illuminating light, holy power, and persistent love,
now, and forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Life shines out at us from even the darkest corners
beckoning us to be drawn into its truth.
With classic precision,
the options for peace are placed before us.
We hesitate, we laugh at the possibilities,
shrug off the responsibilities
and go about our merry way,
happy to leave behind whatever
chaos it may have brought.

Yet, in this hour, we turn toward those corners,
we sink into their deep mysteries,
open ourselves to life's possibilities,
yearn after its truths and notice, feel the weight of,
accept the responsibility life has placed upon us.

We are called to see with the eyes of our hearts
hear from the depths of our souls,
and live as those alive with purpose.

On this Second Sunday of Advent, may the peace and hope of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from Psalm 19*

Shalonda Martin

This is the wisdom of the ancestors.

Thanks be to God!

Advent Prayers

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Now, O Holy One,
we enter sacred time,
time suspended,
when history surrenders to mystery,
and we ourselves are taken in, and taken up,
by the story of peace and hope.

For soon the universe will burst into being.
For soon the galaxies will shine –
lights strung upon a Christmas cosmos.
For soon supernovas will make sacrifices
and our sun will pour itself out
in the service of life.

For soon, the march of life on Earth
will make its exuberant procession –
and be present in lowing cattle,
in a single shining star,
in shepherds and angels,
and in proud parents –
found in a Bethlehem stable.

But now, O God,
the shadows are long
and their threshold
dares us to cross into the night.

Yet soon, Holy One,
you will help us discover
that you are found
in the silence of the cave
and the darkness of the womb.

In these days help us to learn
the mysteries of life
are often obscured by bright lights.

*In these days, help us to look
and to listen for you, O God,
help us to listen for you.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"E'en So, Lord Jesus, Quickly Come"
Laude

PAUL MANZ

Sermon

An Enduring Advent ~ Peace

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Shalonda Martin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Gloria" from Gloria
Cathedral Choir

FRANCIS POULENC

"Glory to God in the highest, and on earth, peace to all people."

***Advent Doxology**

THE FIRST NOEL

Praise God from whom all blessings flow
Praise God all creatures here below
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts
Praise Creator, Redeemer and Holy Ghost
Noël, Noël, Noël, Noël
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

***Prayer of Offering**

Shalonda Martin

God of Peace,
there is no place we can go
where you are not.
You are our God
and we are people made in your image.

As we bring the gifts of our offerings and ourselves –
remind us that you go with us
into this day,
into this week,
into this world –
now and always.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Advent Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Peace is a parent tenderly holding their child.
Peace is the trust shared between friends.
Peace is living unencumbered with a full sense of joy.
Peace is expressing Thanksgiving for concrete blessings.
For the peace gained from the love and memory of
partners and children,

We give thanks.

For the peace gained from love and memory of
families and friends who are like family.

We give thanks.

For the peace gained from the kindness and support
from those who love us,

We give thanks.

For the peace gained from the music of God sung
in creation,

We give thanks.

We realize peace is elusive.

We know there are raging storms in every life.

Yet, each of our lives is graced, and grounded,
by moments of peace and hope.

*For these times of peace and hope;
past, present, and future,
we offer our deepest gratitude
and we say with one voice –
May it forever be so.*

Choral Response

“Glory To God” from *Messiah*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

G.F. HANDEL

*Hymn for the Journey

Put Peace Into Each Other's Hands

ST. COLUMBIA

Put peace into each other's hands and like a treasure hold it,
Protect it like a candle flame, with tenderness enfold it.

Put peace into each other's hands with loving expectation;
Be gentle in your words and ways, in touch with God's creation.

Put peace into each other's hands like bread we break for sharing;
Look people warmly in the eye: our life is meant for caring.

As at communion, shape your hands into a waiting cradle;
The gift of Christ receive, revere, united round the table.

Put Christ into each other's hands to share love's deepest measure;
In love make peace, give peace a chance, and share it like a treasure.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Inside The Music

"Minnesota composer Paul Manz wrote "E'en So, Lord Jesus, Quickly Come" from a place of desperation at the bedside of his sick son. His son was eventually healed, but at the time the situation was uncertain. The piece has become a beloved advent anthem, in part, because of its concentrated emotional clarity, and the peacefulness it eventually embodies. This emotional experience aligns with John's comforting words from Revelation. John spoke from exile to people who were deeply unsure about their own futures. Both of these men were living through a significant challenge as they reflected on their place in the vastness of existence, and of their relationship to the divine. Likewise, Advent is a time of preparation and reflection. John reminds us that love comes from the divine and flows through all beings. The Advent message that "Christ is coming soon" speaks broadly. It is followed by a plaintive but hopeful request for Jesus, as the embodiment of love, to come quickly. The passion Manz infuses into these words through music helps to elevate the power of love in our hearts. Each musical line rises quickly, then falls as quickly but further down the scale, before rising a little bit in recovery. The result is that it feels like sobs. At the words "Rejoice in heaven" the music becomes fuller, and the lines shorter. Though still following similar rises and falls, the melodies stabilize more. Long notes give energy to shorter falls which are followed by more effusive rises. This increased confidence moves quickly into a singular moment in choral music. The sopranos leap above the staff seemingly out of nowhere and the lower parts sing fortissimo at the one time he chooses to repeat text: "for Christ is coming, is coming soon, for Christ is coming soon." The phrase ends with a return to the opening music with all of its energy spent. The sobbing has reached its peak, now the hope begins to shine through. "E'en so," a phrase that is typically a recognition of what is, brings us a sober recognition that love is on its way. The music circles back to that recognition. Our anticipation for love to arrive more quickly ends with the promise that "they need no light, nor lamp, nor sun, for Christ will be their all." As we enter the darkest days of the year, this promise relates to "what is." We can see it with our eyes. The metaphor of light, so often used to signify understanding and clarity, isn't needed here. We have found a new revelation. Even the sun can't outshine the power of love. Although love as divinity is central to the text, the music centers on peacefulness. Manz's music embodies peace in part because it begins with the struggle. We feel the challenge seeping through the notes and phrases, just as we feel the release, and the promise of peace it brings." -Dr. David Harris